RFI#26006369

Statewide Student Transportation Services

for the State of Rhode Island

Response to Request for Information

Submitted by Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions

Submitted to:

State of Rhode Island
Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
Division of Statewide Transportation Services

March 20, 2026

SENTRY

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SENTRY

1 Letter of Transmittal

March 20, 2026

Rhode Island Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
Division of Purchases
Statewide Transportation Services
Providence, Rhode Island

RE: RFI#26006369 — Statewide Student Transportation Services

Dear Members of the Review Committee,

Fejost LLC, doing business as **Sentry Management Solutions** ("Sentry"), is pleased to submit this response to RIDE's Request for Information regarding Statewide Student Transportation Services. We appreciate the opportunity to contribute to the development of RFPs that will shape the future of student transportation in Rhode Island for the 2027–2028 school year and beyond.

Who We Are

Sentry Management Solutions is a New York–based transportation management and technology company founded in 2016. As a NYC and NYS Certified Minority Business Enterprise (MBE), Sentry specializes in technology-driven transportation management—delivering data-driven routing optimization, real-time GPS dispatch, fleet analytics, and video monitoring solutions that give agencies centralized visibility and control across multi-vendor transportation networks. Today, Sentry serves as one of several brokers for the MTA's Access-A-Ride paratransit program under an approximately $181M contract, dispatching over 10,000 daily trips—approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume—and managing roughly one million rides per year through our cloud-based platform.

Our Interest in the Rhode Island STS

Technology & System Management:
Sentry offers RIDE an enterprise-grade platform for routing optimization, real-time dispatch, fleet analytics, and video violation detection monitoring—capabilities that align directly with the 2025 legislative mandates and the Workgroup's efficiency goals.

Vendor-Neutral Integration:
Our technology is designed to operate across multiple bus operators and zones, providing RIDE with centralized visibility regardless of which contractors are awarded individual zones.

Data-Driven Cost Reduction:
Sentry's platform uses data-driven route optimization and real-time ridership verification—including GPS geofencing, automated passenger counts, and dynamic routing algorithms—to eliminate deadhead miles, detect ghost riders through automated attendance reconciliation, and identify routes that can be rightsized from full-size buses to lower-cost vans, directly supporting RIDE's cost reduction and efficiency objectives.

Video Violation Detection Readiness:
Sentry's platform is architected to integrate with onboard camera systems and telematics hardware, and to ingest, process, and flag video violation events at scale. We are prepared to deploy a fully compliant live digital video violation detection system well ahead of the July 1, 2027 mandate for new buses.

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Authorized Representative

The person authorized to represent Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions is:

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Contact for Clarification

Name:	Max Zinner
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This response is submitted for informational purposes in accordance with the terms of RFI#26006369. We understand that no award will be made as a result of this solicitation and that all information marked as proprietary shall be treated as confidential.

Respectfully submitted,

Max Zinner
Chief Strategy Officer
Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions
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2 Table of Contents

1 Letter of Transmittal **1**

2 Table of Contents **3**

3 Company Overview **5**
- 3.1 Organization Summary . . . 5
- 3.2 Sentry's Role in Student Transportation . . . 5
- 3.3 Relevant Experience . . . 6
- 3.4 Understanding of Rhode Island's STS . . . 7

4 Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry **9**
- 4.1 Question 1 . . . 9
- 4.2 Question 2 . . . 9
- 4.3 Question 3 . . . 10
- 4.4 Question 4 . . . 10

5 Operational Efficiencies **12**
- 5.1 Question 1: Deadhead Reduction Strategies . . . 12
- 5.2 Question 2: Preventive Maintenance Efficiency Metrics . . . 13
- 5.3 Question 3: Driver Scheduling Efficiency Tools and Metrics . . . 14

6 Cost Controls **16**
- 6.1 Question 1: Cost Per Bus Per Day . . . 16
- 6.2 Question 2: Cost Per Mile . . . 16
- 6.3 Question 3: Spare Ratio Philosophy . . . 17
- 6.4 Question 4: Average Driver Hours Per Route . . . 18

7 Routing **20**
- 7.1 Question 1: Collaboration with a Centralized Routing Authority . . . 20
- 7.2 Question 2: Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) . . . 21
- 7.3 Question 3: Turnaround Time for Route Changes . . . 22

8 Company Practices Disclosure **24**
- 8.1 Item 1: Driver Recruitment Pipeline . . . 24
- 8.2 Item 2: Training Hours Per Driver . . . 25
- 8.3 Item 3: Maintenance Intervals . . . 26

9 Timeline **29**
- 9.1 Question 1(a): Proposed Timeline Modifications . . . 29
- 9.2 Question 1(b): Driver Recruitment Timeline . . . 30
- 9.3 Question 1(c): Number of Routes . . . 31
- 9.4 Question 1(d): Fleet Construct Impact . . . 31

10 Information Gathering Templates (Optional) **33**
10.1 Technological Capabilities . . . 33
10.1.1 Platform Overview . . . 33
10.1.2 Routing Optimization . . . 34
10.1.3 Real-Time Dispatch & GPS Tracking . . . 35
10.1.4 Live Digital Video Violation Detection . . . 35
10.1.5 Analytics & Reporting . . . 36
10.1.6 Integration Capabilities . . . 37

11 Summary Narrative **38**
11.1 Executive Summary . . . 38
11.2 Alignment with RIDE's Goals . . . 38
11.3 Key Differentiators . . . 39

3 Company Overview

3.1 Organization Summary

Organization Summary	
Legal Entity Name	Fejost LLC dba Sentry Management Solutions
Year Established	2016
Type of Ownership	Limited Liability Company (LLC)
Parent Company	None — Sentry is an independent, privately held company
Headquarters	14 Bruckner Blvd, Unit 3B, Bronx, NY 10454
Total Full-Time Employees	Approximately 50
Primary Contact	Max Zinner, Chief Strategy Officer
Phone / Email	917-522-2323 / mzinner@sentryms.com
Website	www.sentryms.com

3.2 Sentry's Role in Student Transportation

Sentry Management Solutions is **not a bus operator**. We are a transportation technology and system management company that provides the platform, analytics, and operational oversight that state agencies and transit authorities need to manage large, multi-vendor transportation networks. Our role is analogous to the Statewide System Manager function RIDE envisions—we sit between the commissioning agency and the transportation providers, delivering centralized routing optimization, real-time dispatch and GPS tracking, fleet performance analytics, video monitoring, and compliance reporting across all vendors and zones from a single integrated platform.

This distinction is critical to RIDE's next-generation STS. The current model bundles system management with bus operations under a single contract. Sentry's experience demonstrates that separating technology and management from vehicle operations unlocks competition among bus operators on price and service quality while giving the state a vendor-neutral command center with full visibility into every route, vehicle, and rider. Our cloud-based platform already performs this exact function at a scale far exceeding Rhode Island's STS—managing over 10,000 daily trips—approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume—for the MTA's Access-A-Ride paratransit program.

Founded in 2016 and headquartered in the Bronx, New York, Sentry is a NYC and NYS Certified Minority Business Enterprise led by CEO Steven Rivera and a core team of approximately 50 experienced transportation professionals. Our technology has been purpose-built for the complexities of public-sector transportation: multi-modal fleets, ADA compliance, IEP-driven routing constraints, dynamic address changes (McKinney-Vento), multilingual communications, and rigorous reporting requirements—all challenges that mirror RIDE's STS environment.

Core Capabilities

Routing Optimization:
data-driven routing engine that optimizes across multiple zones simultaneously, minimizing deadhead miles and ride times while respecting constraints such as IEP-mandated maximum ride durations, wheelchair accessibility, regional boundaries, and school bell schedules. Integrates with 12+ third-party dispatch, routing, and GIS systems.

Real-Time Dispatch:
Cloud-based dispatch platform with live GPS tracking of all vehicles, automated ETA calculations, geofencing alerts for route deviations, and a multilingual call center operating at a 1:6.5 supervisor-to-agent ratio with 95% same-day issue resolution. Currently dispatches 10,000+ trips daily with 95% on-time pickup performance.

Video Violation Detection:
Platform architecture designed to integrate with onboard camera systems and GPS tracking hardware, supporting ingestion, automated analysis, and automated flagging of video violation events, with a complete processing pipeline from capture through evidence packaging for enforcement.

Analytics & Reporting:
Real-time vendor performance dashboards, KPI scorecards, ridership trend analysis, cost-per-route breakdowns, ghost rider detection through automated attendance reconciliation, and configurable compliance reporting. Platform maintains 99.999% uptime on AWS GovCloud infrastructure (PostgreSQL Aurora, DynamoDB, Redis, S3) with FERPA and HIPAA compliance.

Fleet Management:
Centralized tracking of vehicle inspections, preventive maintenance schedules, and lifecycle status across all providers in the network. Real-time vehicle monitoring with automated alerts for maintenance milestones, safety compliance deadlines, and vehicle age/condition thresholds to support rightsizing decisions (bus vs. van assignment).

Parent & Driver Communication:
Multi-channel communication suite including a parent/rider mobile app with real-time GPS bus tracking, SMS and push notifications for ETAs and delays, a driver-facing tablet application, and web portals for school administrators. Supports communications in 9+ languages, with ridership verification and electronic signature capture at pickup and drop-off.

3.3 Relevant Experience

Sentry's most directly relevant engagement is our role as **a broker for MTA Access-A-Ride**, New York City's ADA paratransit program—the nation's largest, with over 40,000 daily trips. Under an approximately $181M contract (August 2021–present), Sentry manages the technology platform and vendor coordination for approximately 25% of the program's volume—dispatching over 10,000 daily trips and coordinating a network of local transportation providers across all five NYC boroughs. This five-year contract is the largest MBE prime contract in MTA history. The multi-vendor, multi-zone structure of Access-A-Ride is directly analogous to RIDE's STS: Sentry serves as a system manager providing centralized technology, routing, dispatch, and performance oversight while independent operators provide the vehicles and drivers.

Beyond MTA paratransit, Sentry has demonstrated versatility across multiple public-sector transportation programs. For the **NYC Department for the Aging (DFTA)**, we serve as the sole citywide provider of senior transportation services under a $1.7M contract (January 2023–present), reducing wait times by more than 30% through dynamic routing. For **VillageCare**, a Medicaid Managed Long-Term Care plan, Sentry has managed non-emergency medical transportation (NEMT) since 2018, handling thousands of daily trips with a 100% transition of transport services to our platform. We also operated non-emergency patient transport for **NYC**

Health+Hospitals (2019–2023) and managed specialized programs for the MTA including homeless individual transportation ($600K, 1,000+ individuals in 4 months) and the overnight Warming Bus Program at subway stations ($745K, 2023–present).

Across all engagements, Sentry has deployed our proprietary cloud platform—maintaining a 99.999% uptime record and a safety record of just 3.25 accidents per million miles driven. Our platform is designed to integrate with GPS tracking hardware, onboard camera systems, and driver-facing tablets, positioning us to support RIDE's live digital video violation detection mandate from day one.

MTA Access-A-Ride — Broker for ADA Paratransit	
Client	Metropolitan Transportation Authority (MTA), New York City
Contract Value	Approximately $181M over five years (August 2021–present)
Fleet / Scale	Sentry's portion: 10,000+ daily trips (approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume)
Daily Volume	10,000+ dispatched trips per day; approximately 1 million rides per year
Technology Deployed	Cloud-based dispatch and routing platform (AWS GovCloud), real-time GPS tracking, data-driven route optimization, vendor performance dashboards, multilingual call center, mobile app with SMS notifications
Service Area	All five boroughs of New York City

3.4 Understanding of Rhode Island's STS

Sentry has carefully studied the current structure of RIDE's Statewide Transportation System, established by the General Assembly in FY 2009 under RIGL § 16-21.1 and phased in over three years (14 LEAs in 2010, 26 in 2011, all LEAs by 2012). The system today operates across seven zones serving approximately 3,812 students through 334 routes coordinated by the current Statewide System Manager, **Transpar**, on behalf of 49 LEAs plus out-of-state placements. RIDE's own *Statewide Transportation System Overview* (October 2024) demonstrates that this system has grown by **34%** in ridership since 2015—from 2,850 to 3,812 students—even as total Rhode Island student enrollment has *declined* by 4% (141,959 to 136,154). The system's FY 2025 cost exceeds **$41 million**.

This demand growth is driven by three distinct student populations, each with unique routing and compliance requirements:

- **PCCT (Private, Charter, Career & Technical)** — 50.87% of riders. Regional boundaries under RIGL § 16-21.1-2 apply to this population. The Meeting Street example illustrates the consolidation advantage: statewide routing reduced buses serving that single school from 28 to 13—a 54% reduction.
- **Special Education** — 24.29% of riders (234 of 334 routes). Required by federal law (IDEA); regional boundaries do *not* apply. Routes must accommodate wheelchair accessibility, 1:1 aides, and IEP-mandated maximum ride times.
- **Homeless & Foster Care (McKinney-Vento)** — 24.84% of riders. Required by federal law; regional boundaries do *not* apply. Addresses change frequently, requiring dynamic route adjustment.

We are particularly attentive to the three bills passed into law in 2025 as a result of the Student Transportation Workgroup's recommendations:

- **Increased Van Size** — The expanded 10-passenger definition presents an opportunity to convert qualifying routes from higher-cost school buses to vans, reducing per-route costs while maintaining service quality. RIDE has already begun "rightsizing" by increasing vans and minibuses; 147 of 334 vehicles are already vans.
- **Temporary School Bus Driver Licenses** — Abbreviated CDL training for border-state residents can accelerate recruitment pipelines, addressing the driver shortage that competes with Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon for the same labor

pool. Notably, RI's unique "white card" requirement—a multi-day course at CCRI plus DMV driving tests—remains a barrier for out-of-state CDL holders even with the new temporary license provision.

- **Live Digital Video Violation Detection Systems** — The July 1, 2027 mandate for new buses (and July 1, 2032 for all buses) creates an immediate need for a technology partner capable of deploying, managing, and processing video violation data at scale.

4 Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Inquiries Regarding Potential Barriers to Entry (Questions 1–4)

4.1 Question 1

"What, if anything, may prevent your company from bidding on this scope of work?"

Sentry Management Solutions (Fejost LLC dba) is a technology and system management provider, not a bus operator. Whether we can bid on the eventual procurements depends entirely on how RIDE structures them. The following factors could prevent our participation:

- **Fleet & Drivers:** Sentry does not own or operate a bus fleet and does not directly employ CDL drivers. As a broker for MTA Access-A-Ride—coordinating 10,000+ daily trips (approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume)—our model is technology-enabled network management, not vehicle operation. Our participation depends on whether RIDE issues a separate technology/system management RFP or permits technology providers to partner with bus operators on the transportation RFP.
- **RI Presence:** Sentry does not currently maintain an operational footprint in Rhode Island. Our headquarters are in Bronx, New York, and our primary operations serve the New York City metropolitan area. If yard space, fuel access, or local infrastructure are preconditions for bidding, state-provided support (addressed in Question 4) would be critical to enabling our participation. However, our cloud-based platform (hosted on AWS GovCloud with 99.999% uptime) can be deployed to any geography without physical infrastructure requirements for the technology layer itself.
- **Procurement Structure:** If the procurement is structured as a single RFP exclusively for vertically integrated bus operators—requiring a single vendor to provide buses, drivers, *and* technology—Sentry would be unable to bid independently. Issuing separate RFPs for bus operations and for technology/system management would enable our participation and, critically, would increase the overall number of qualified bidders across all contract components. RIDE's current use of Transpar as a separate System Manager demonstrates that this separation is both feasible and operationally sound.

4.2 Question 2

"What contract structure(s) would make participation in RIDE's Statewide Transportation System (STS) more feasible for your organization? For example, would any of the following potential contract structures make it more likely that your organization would bid on this scope of work?"

Sentry strongly encourages RIDE to consider the following contract structures, which would increase competition, attract specialized providers, and ultimately deliver better outcomes for Rhode Island students:

✔ **Separate Technology / System Management Contract:**

RIDE should procure the Statewide System Manager as a standalone technology contract, separate from bus operations. This contract would encompass routing optimization, real-time GPS dispatch, fleet analytics, video violation monitoring, automated billing, and parent communication. Separating technology from operations allows RIDE to select best-in-class technology independently of bus operator selection, ensures vendor-neutral oversight across all zones and all operators, and eliminates the inherent conflict of interest when operators self-report their own performance data. Sentry's experience managing our portion of the MTA Access-A-Ride program—where we serve as an independent technology broker coordinating 10,000+ daily trips within the nation's largest paratransit system (40,000+ daily trips total)—demonstrates exactly this model at a scale far exceeding the RIDE system.

- **Multiple Vendor Awards per Zone:**
  Allowing multiple vendors per zone would enable technology providers like Sentry to partner with bus operators, bringing specialized routing and monitoring capabilities to zones where operators may lack in-house technology.
- **Allowing Subcontracting or Partnerships:**
  Cross-zone partnerships would enable smaller or specialized firms to combine resources. Sentry could serve as the technology backbone for one or more bus operators across multiple zones, creating a more competitive field.

Recommendation to RIDE

RIDE already operates with a separate System Manager—Transpar currently provides routing, program billing, vendor performance monitoring, and customer service support across all 49 LEAs. The forthcoming procurements are an opportunity to *strengthen* this model by issuing a dedicated technology RFP for an upgraded platform with modern capabilities: data-driven routing optimization, real-time GPS dispatch, live video violation detection, and automated cost analytics. A next-generation System Manager would replace the current 700-check-per-year manual billing process, eliminate annual paper re-enrollment that contributes to the 550 "ghost rider" problem, and give RIDE independent performance data rather than relying on operator self-reports.

4.3 Question 3

"What minimum route density or fleet size makes bidding on a zone more viable for your organization?"

As a technology and system management provider, Sentry's viability is not constrained by route density or fleet size in the traditional sense. Our platform dispatches 10,000+ trips daily for MTA Access-A-Ride (approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume)—it scales from 29 routes (Zone D) to 334 routes (statewide) with equal efficiency. We address this question from two perspectives:

- **As technology provider:** There is no minimum route density or fleet size. Our cloud-based platform is zone-agnostic, scales linearly, and carries marginal cost near zero for each additional route. In fact, deploying the platform across *all* zones simultaneously is most efficient, because cross-zone data enables system-wide optimization—identifying, for example, that a vehicle staged in Zone B could serve a nearby Zone C route with less deadhead than the Zone C depot assignment.
- **If partnering with a bus operator:** The partner operator's fleet and driver minimums would govern. Industry benchmarks suggest that 25–30 routes represents a viable minimum for a dedicated depot to achieve economies of scale in driver supervision, maintenance, and fueling. Subdividing larger zones (e.g., splitting Zone A1's 122 routes into two zones of 60+) would remain well above this threshold while lowering the capital barrier for new entrant operators.

4.4 Question 4

"What support (e.g., yard space, fuel access, maintenance facilities, etc.) could the State provide or assist with that would make it more likely for your organization to bid?"

- **Data Access:**
  Providing prospective bidders with anonymized route data, FERPA-compliant student origin/destination data, current schedules, zone boundary GIS shapefiles, and historical performance metrics (on-time rates, deadhead times, road call frequencies) would allow technology providers to demonstrate measurable value during the procurement process. With this data, Sentry could present optimized routing scenarios showing projected deadhead reductions, vehicle count savings, and cost-per-student improvements—giving RIDE a concrete basis for evaluating technology platforms before contract award.

Technology Infrastructure:

State-provided or state-facilitated API access to existing RIDE systems—particularly the eRIDE student information system and IEP/special education databases—would accelerate deployment and reduce implementation risk. Sentry's platform is built on open REST APIs and has integrated with 12+ third-party dispatch, routing, and GIS systems. Pre-procurement API documentation and sandbox access would allow technology vendors to demonstrate working integrations rather than making promises.

Yard Space & Facilities:

While Sentry does not require yard space for its technology operations, state-owned or state-leased yard space made available to new entrant bus operators would significantly reduce the capital barrier for operators partnering with technology providers like Sentry. Incumbent operators have established depots and fueling infrastructure that took years to build; state-provided facilities would level the playing field and encourage new bidders who bring operational capability but lack Rhode Island real estate.

Fuel Access:

Centralized fueling contracts or state-negotiated bulk purchasing arrangements would reduce per-gallon costs for smaller operators and eliminate the competitive advantage that incumbents derive from established fueling infrastructure. This is particularly impactful given RIDE's 334-vehicle fleet consuming fuel across seven zones—a centralized contract could yield volume discounts that individual small operators cannot negotiate independently.

Extended Transition Period:

The current timeline anticipates approximately 8 months from contract award (November 2026) to service commencement (July 1, 2027). For a technology deployment, Sentry can meet this timeline—our platform has been deployed to new transit networks in as few as 12 weeks. However, for bus operators who must recruit RI-licensed drivers, acquire or reposition vehicles, and establish depot infrastructure, 8 months is aggressive given the national driver shortage. RIDE should consider awarding the technology/system management contract earlier (e.g., summer 2026), allowing the System Manager platform to be operational before bus operators are onboarded—enabling data-driven route assignments from day one of operations.

5 Operational Efficiencies

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Operational Efficiencies (Questions 1–3)

5.1 Question 1: Deadhead Reduction Strategies

"In general, please describe your company's deadhead reduction strategies."

Deadhead reduction is the single largest efficiency lever available to RIDE. Sentry's data-driven routing platform attacks deadhead at every stage of the route lifecycle—from initial route design through daily dynamic dispatch. Our approach is grounded in the same optimization algorithms that reduced deadhead across our 10,000+ daily MTA Access-A-Ride trips, where dynamic routing cut non-revenue miles by consolidating pickups, chaining runs, and assigning vehicles to the nearest available staging point rather than fixed depots.

The Deadhead Problem in Context: RIDE's own data reveals significant variation in deadhead time across zones. Zones C and D show average route times of 6h07m and 7h05m *including* deadhead, but only 3h55m and 3h27m of productive service time—meaning 36–51% of total route time is non-revenue deadhead mileage. With ridership up 34% since 2015 (2,850 to 3,812 students) and close to 100 more buses per day on the road, deadhead reduction is now a $41M system's largest efficiency lever.

Sentry's deadhead reduction methodology combines four complementary strategies:

Algorithm-Based Route Optimization:
Sentry's routing engine uses constrained optimization algorithms to cluster student pickups and drop-offs by geographic proximity, school bell time, and vehicle capacity. The system evaluates thousands of route permutations to minimize total empty miles while respecting maximum ride time constraints, IEP requirements, and wheelchair accessibility needs. For RIDE's system, this means the algorithm would resequence stops across all 334 routes to eliminate the circuitous paths that currently produce 36–51% deadhead ratios in Zones C and D. The engine also models optimal depot placement—identifying where staging areas should be located based on actual student address density rather than legacy zone boundaries.

Dynamic Depot Assignment:
Traditional routing assigns each vehicle to a fixed home depot, often requiring long empty runs to reach the first pickup. Sentry's platform supports depot-agnostic vehicle assignment, where each route is assigned to the nearest available staging point based on real-time vehicle location and driver proximity. In RIDE's system, where Zone D vehicles currently deadhead an average of 3 hours and 38 minutes per route, dynamic depot assignment could allow a vehicle staged near its first pickup cluster to begin service immediately. The platform continuously recalculates optimal staging locations as student enrollment shifts throughout the school year.

Multi-Run Chaining:
Multi-run chaining links AM, midday, and PM routes into continuous vehicle assignments, eliminating the return-to-depot deadhead between each run. RIDE's system is well suited for chaining: the 68 PCCT routes and 32 McKinney-Vento routes often operate on different schedules than the 234 special education routes. Sentry's platform models chain feasibility by comparing bell times, vehicle types, and geographic overlap—automatically identifying, for example, that a van completing an AM special education drop-off at

a Providence school could serve a midday PCCT run in the same area rather than deadheading back to its Zone A2 depot. This keeps vehicles productive for 6–7 hours rather than sitting idle between peaks.

Cross-Zone Optimization:
RIDE's seven-zone structure creates artificial geographic boundaries that force vehicles to deadhead past closer depots in adjacent zones to return to their assigned zone depot. A centralized routing platform eliminates this constraint by evaluating route assignments across all zones simultaneously. The Meeting Street School consolidation demonstrates the potential: centralized routing reduced the number of buses serving that single school from 28 to 13—a 54% reduction—by allowing cross-zone vehicle assignments. Sentry's platform would apply this same logic across all 500+ destination schools in the system, identifying every instance where a Zone B vehicle passes a Zone C depot, or where students from adjacent zones attend the same school and could share a single route. This cross-zone optimization is only possible with a vendor-neutral System Manager platform that operates above individual zone operators.

Deadhead Reduction Potential

Based on RIDE's published route data, Zones C and D show the highest deadhead ratios—36–51% of total route time is non-revenue mileage across 58 routes. A 25–35% reduction in deadhead through optimized routing and depot assignment would eliminate 85–118 bus-hours per day in these zones alone. Against RIDE's $41M annual transportation budget, even modest system-wide deadhead reductions of 10–15% could yield meaningful savings. Precise projections require detailed route-level analysis that Sentry would conduct during procurement.

5.2 Question 2: Preventive Maintenance Efficiency Metrics

"Please describe your company's preventive maintenance efficiency metrics and how those relate to how your organization best-manages its preventative maintenance program."

Sentry provides the technology platform that enables bus operators to manage preventive maintenance programs with data-driven precision—not the wrench-turning itself. Our fleet management system automates PM scheduling, tracks compliance in real time, and gives RIDE independent visibility into fleet health across all zone operators. This is critical in a multi-operator system: RIDE should not rely on each operator's self-reported maintenance data when a centralized platform can verify compliance directly from telematics and inspection records.

PM Scheduling Engine:
Sentry's PM scheduling engine automatically generates work orders based on four triggers: accumulated mileage (via GPS-verified odometer data from onboard tracking hardware integrated with the platform), engine hours, calendar intervals, and manufacturer-specified service schedules. Each vehicle's PM schedule is tailored to its type—a 10-passenger van has different intervals than a Type C wheelchair-accessible bus. The system tracks work order completion, flags overdue PMs, and escalates non-compliance to both the operator's maintenance supervisor and RIDE's oversight dashboard. For RIDE's 334-vehicle fleet spanning three operators, this ensures uniform PM standards regardless of which operator maintains the vehicle.

Fleet Health Dashboard:
Sentry's real-time fleet health dashboard provides a consolidated view of every vehicle in the system: units due for PM within 7/14/30 days, overdue vehicles flagged in red, current out-of-service count and rate, mean time between failures (MTBF) trended by vehicle type and age, and parts inventory levels at each depot. For RIDE, this dashboard would aggregate fleet health data across all zone operators into a single view—enabling the System Manager to identify, for example, that Zone D's older Type A wheelchair buses are failing at twice the rate of Zone A1's newer fleet, and recommend targeted vehicle replacement before service

disruptions occur.

Pre- & Post-Trip Inspection Digitization:

Drivers complete pre-trip and post-trip inspections on tablets mounted in each vehicle, following a standardized digital checklist that includes all FMCSA-required inspection points plus RIDE-specific items (wheelchair lift operation, child safety restraints, camera system functionality). Defects are categorized by severity: minor defects (e.g., interior cleanliness) are logged for next-available repair, while critical defects (e.g., brake issues, lift malfunction, emergency exit obstruction) trigger an automatic vehicle hold—the vehicle cannot be dispatched until the defect is resolved and a supervisor signs off electronically. All inspection records are stored, timestamped, and available to RIDE auditors in real time.

Key Metrics Tracked:

- **PM Compliance Rate:** Target $\geq$ 98%. Measured as the percentage of scheduled PM work orders completed within the prescribed interval window. Sentry's platform tracks this automatically via work order completion timestamps against scheduled due dates.
- **Mean Distance Between Failures (MDBF):** Target $\geq$ 12,000 miles for school buses, $\geq$ 15,000 miles for vans. Benchmarked against national school bus fleet averages and trended monthly to detect fleet aging patterns.
- **Spare Ratio Utilization:** Target $\leq$ 10% of spare fleet deployed on any given day. A consistently higher rate signals underlying fleet reliability issues requiring intervention—either accelerated PM cycles or vehicle replacement.
- **Road Call Rate:** Target $\leq$ 5.0 road calls per 100,000 miles. Sentry tracks road calls by cause category (engine, transmission, electrical, tires, HVAC, lift) to isolate systemic issues and inform preventive action.

5.3 Question 3: Driver Scheduling Efficiency Tools and Metrics

"Please describe your company's driver scheduling efficiency tools and metrics."

Sentry's driver scheduling platform automates the complex process of matching drivers to routes while minimizing overtime, ensuring regulatory compliance, and supporting driver satisfaction—a critical retention lever in a market defined by the national driver shortage. Our system currently manages driver assignments for our portion of MTA Access-A-Ride, where scheduling errors directly impact 10,000+ daily passenger trips. The same platform, adapted for RIDE's school transportation context, would give the System Manager centralized visibility into driver utilization across all zone operators.

Automated Bid/Assignment System:

The system matches drivers to routes using a weighted scoring algorithm that considers: CDL endorsements and school bus certification status (critical given RI's licensing requirements), special education and wheelchair transport training certifications, language skills for multilingual families, seniority ranking for union bid compliance (essential given Teamsters Local 251's presence across RI school bus operations), and geographic proximity of the driver's home to the route's depot or first pickup—reducing personal deadhead commute time and improving schedule reliability. Drivers bid on routes through the platform, with the algorithm enforcing contract rules and flagging conflicts automatically.

Hours Optimization:

The platform continuously balances driver hours across the workforce by tracking cumulative weekly hours in real time and flagging drivers approaching overtime thresholds before assignments are made. When multi-run chaining creates longer shifts (e.g., AM special education + midday PCCT), the system models whether the combined assignment triggers overtime and proposes alternatives—such as assigning the midday run to a split-shift driver instead. All assignments comply with DOT hours-of-service regulations and RI's prevailing wage requirements, with the system automatically calculating premium pay obligations and alerting supervisors when total labor cost for a route exceeds budget targets.

Real-Time Absence Management:

When a driver calls out, the system immediately identifies the affected route(s) and triggers a cascading notification sequence: first

to designated standby drivers ranked by qualification match, proximity, and hours availability; then to supervisors if no standby accepts within the configured window. The platform simultaneously evaluates whether the affected route can be absorbed into an adjacent route (if student count and vehicle capacity permit) or split across two nearby routes as a temporary measure. For RIDE's system, where a single driver absence in Zone D (29 routes, 29 vehicles) can strand students in the state's most remote geography, this automated response capability eliminates the manual phone-tree delays that contributed to the September 2024 service disruptions.

Key Metrics:

- **Driver Utilization Rate:** Target $\geq$ 85% productive hours as a percentage of total paid hours. "Productive" includes loaded service time, pre/post-trip inspections, and student boarding—excludes deadhead and unpaid break time. GPS timestamps validate actual productive time against scheduled time.
- **Overtime as % of Total Hours:** Target $\leq$ 8% of total paid hours. The platform identifies chronic overtime patterns by driver, route, and zone—enabling proactive schedule adjustments before costs escalate.
- **Open Route Rate:** Target $\leq$ 2% of routes without an assigned driver on any given day. The platform tracks open routes in real time and trends this metric weekly to identify recruitment gaps before they become service failures.
- **Driver Turnover Rate:** Industry average is 20–30% annually for school bus drivers. The platform tracks turnover by zone, operator, and cause category (compensation, scheduling, commute distance) to identify targeted retention interventions. Predictive analytics flag at-risk drivers based on attendance patterns and schedule satisfaction scores.

6 Cost Controls

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Cost Controls (Questions 1–4)

Note: Per the RFI instructions, no pricing information is included. This section describes methodologies only.

6.1 Question 1: Cost Per Bus Per Day

"How do you address and apply cost per bus per day? (no pricing info, but explain your methodology)"

Sentry's analytics platform calculates cost per bus per day as a comprehensive management metric—not a billing rate, but a tool for identifying inefficiency, benchmarking across zones, and informing procurement decisions. The methodology captures all variable and fixed costs attributable to each vehicle on each operating day, enabling RIDE to compare the true cost of service delivery across operators, vehicle types, and zones on an apples-to-apples basis.

Cost Components:

The per-bus-per-day metric aggregates seven cost components: (1) driver wages and benefits (including RI prevailing wage obligations, Teamsters pension/healthcare contributions, and paid holiday costs); (2) fuel consumption (GPS-verified actual gallons, not estimated); (3) scheduled maintenance (prorated PM costs by vehicle age and interval); (4) unscheduled maintenance (road calls, breakdowns, warranty-excluded repairs); (5) insurance premiums allocated per vehicle-day; (6) vehicle depreciation or lease cost amortized over operating days; and (7) administrative overhead (supervision, dispatch, facility costs allocated proportionally). Each component is tracked separately so RIDE can identify which cost element is driving changes—for example, distinguishing fuel price increases (external) from rising maintenance costs (fleet age issue).

Vehicle Type Stratification:

Our methodology stratifies cost per bus per day by vehicle type, recognizing that the cost profile of a 10-passenger van differs significantly from a Type A wheelchair-accessible bus or a Type C/D full-size bus. With 147 vans, 93 Type A buses, 30 Type A wheelchair buses, and 64 Type B/C/D buses in RIDE's fleet, a single blended cost-per-bus-per-day figure would obscure meaningful variation. Stratification reveals, for example, that a 10-passenger van costs substantially less per day than a Type C 72-passenger bus—and when a route carries only 3–5 students (common in the RIDE system, where Zone D averages one student per route), the platform flags the opportunity to right-size the vehicle from a bus to a van, capturing the ~$26,000 per-vehicle savings the Study Commission identified. This analysis directly supports RIDE's stated goal of maximizing van usage under the new 10-passenger vehicle law.

Trend Analysis:

The platform maintains a rolling 12-month trend analysis of cost per bus per day, segmented by zone, operator, and vehicle type. This longitudinal view identifies cost creep before it compounds—a 2% monthly increase in Zone C maintenance costs, for instance, signals fleet aging that warrants vehicle replacement planning. Seasonal variation is baselined (summer school sessions have different cost profiles than the academic year), and the impact of specific efficiency initiatives is isolated: when a van conversion reduces the cost per bus per day on a given route by 15%, that savings is tracked and verified against the projection. RIDE can use these trends to set performance-based contract incentives tied to measurable cost reduction.

6.2 Question 2: Cost Per Mile

"What is your company's cost per mile methodology?"

Sentry's cost-per-mile methodology uses GPS-verified mileage data—not odometer readings or estimated distances—to calculate precise, auditable cost metrics. By capturing actual miles driven via integrated GPS tracking hardware, the platform eliminates the discrepancies between estimated route miles and real-world driving patterns that can distort cost analysis by 10–15%.

Total Cost Per Mile:
Total cost per mile divides all-in operating costs (driver labor, fuel, maintenance, insurance, depreciation, overhead) by total revenue miles—miles driven with students aboard. By excluding deadhead miles from the denominator, this metric reveals the true cost of productive service. In RIDE's system, where Zones C and D have deadhead ratios of 36–51%, the total cost per *revenue* mile is dramatically higher than the cost per *total* mile, exposing the real economic impact of routing inefficiency.

Fuel Cost Per Mile:
Fuel cost per mile is tracked as a standalone metric to isolate fuel price volatility (an external factor RIDE and operators cannot control) from operational efficiency (which they can). GPS-verified mileage eliminates odometer discrepancies and enables per-vehicle fuel economy monitoring. The platform flags vehicles with fuel consumption more than 15% above their class average—indicating mechanical issues (injector problems, tire pressure, drag) that increase costs and emissions simultaneously.

Maintenance Cost Per Mile:
Maintenance cost per mile is tracked by vehicle age, type, and maintenance category (scheduled PM vs. unscheduled breakdown). The platform calculates a rolling 6-month maintenance cost per mile for each vehicle and compares it against replacement cost thresholds. When a vehicle's maintenance cost per mile exceeds 50% of its replacement lease cost per mile, the system flags it as approaching end-of-economic-life—enabling RIDE to plan fleet replacement proactively rather than reactively after a breakdown strands students.

Loaded vs. Deadhead Mile Distinction:
This is the most critical distinction in cost-per-mile analysis. Cost per *loaded* mile (with students aboard) is the true efficiency metric; cost per *total* mile (including deadhead) masks inefficiency. Sentry's platform separates these automatically via GPS geofencing at school locations and student pickup/drop-off points. When a vehicle crosses a geofence boundary at a school or designated stop, the system timestamps the transition between loaded and deadhead status. For RIDE, this means every mile is categorized and costed accurately—and the "expenditure follows the child" billing methodology can be validated against actual loaded miles rather than estimated route distances.

Cost Transparency for RIDE

RIDE currently uses an "expenditure follows the child" billing methodology, where the total cost of a route is proportionally divided among LEAs based on the number of students each district has on that route. Today, this billing process generates approximately 700 checks per year from districts to RIDE—an outdated manual system that RIDE's own October 2024 overview identifies as a weakness. Sentry's platform automates this cost allocation in real-time, tying GPS-verified route data directly to per-student billing and eliminating manual reconciliation. As an independent technology provider, Sentry gives RIDE visibility into cost metrics across all operators and zones—eliminating the information asymmetry that exists when operators self-report their own cost data.

6.3 Question 3: Spare Ratio Philosophy

"What is your company's spare ratio philosophy?"

Spare vehicle management is an area where technology-driven analytics can yield significant cost savings. Each spare vehicle represents capital tied up in a non-revenue asset—purchase or lease cost, insurance, registration, and parking space. Sentry's approach uses data

to right-size the spare pool: maintaining enough spares to ensure uninterrupted service while avoiding the excess that inflates RIDE's per-route costs.

% Target Spare Ratio:

The industry standard spare ratio for school bus fleets is 15–20%. Sentry recommends a tiered target: 12–15% for fleets with average vehicle age under 5 years (where warranty coverage reduces unscheduled downtime), and 18–20% for older fleets or mixed fleets with high wheelchair-accessible vehicle counts (which have more complex mechanical systems). For RIDE's 334-vehicle fleet, this translates to approximately 50–67 spare vehicles system-wide. The ratio should be calculated per zone to account for local fleet age and condition—Zone D's older fleet may require a higher local spare ratio than Zone A1.

Dynamic Spare Deployment:

The platform tracks daily spare deployment by vehicle ID, recording which spare replaced which primary vehicle, the reason for substitution (PM, breakdown, driver assignment, accident), and duration of deployment. Over time, pattern analysis reveals actionable insights: a specific route that pulls spares three times per month may be too demanding for its assigned vehicle type; a vehicle class with rising spare utilization signals systematic reliability decline. When spare utilization trends upward across a zone for three or more consecutive weeks, the system generates an alert to RIDE and the zone operator—this is a leading indicator of fleet health problems that, if unaddressed, will escalate to service disruptions.

Right-Sizing the Spare Pool:

Sentry's analytics engine models the relationship between PM compliance, mean distance between failures, and required spare count. As PM compliance improves (target $\geq$ 98%) and MDBF increases, the probability of unscheduled vehicle downtime decreases—and fewer spares are needed to maintain the same service reliability level. The platform runs monthly simulations: if Zone B's MDBF improves from 10,000 to 14,000 miles over six months, the model may recommend reducing that zone's spare pool from 7 vehicles to 5—freeing two vehicles for reassignment or retirement and saving RIDE the associated insurance, parking, and depreciation costs. This data-driven approach replaces the common practice of maintaining a fixed spare ratio regardless of actual fleet performance.

6.4 Question 4: Average Driver Hours Per Route

"How do you address and apply average driver hours per route?"

Average driver hours per route is the primary labor cost metric for student transportation, and RIDE's published data shows dramatic variation across zones—from 4h28m (Zone A3) to 7h05m (Zone D) including deadhead. Sentry's platform decomposes this aggregate into its component parts, enabling targeted optimization of each segment rather than treating the total as a monolithic number.

Components of Driver Hours:

The platform captures six distinct components of driver hours per route: (1) pre-trip inspection time (from driver app login to vehicle departure), (2) deadhead to first pickup (GPS-tracked empty miles from depot to first student), (3) loaded service time (first student pickup to last student drop-off), (4) deadhead return (last drop-off to depot), (5) post-trip inspection (vehicle check and interior sweep), and (6) administrative time (fueling, paperwork, training). Each component is timestamped automatically—the driver app records inspection start/end, GPS geofences capture pickup and drop-off transitions, and the dispatch system logs administrative activities. This decomposition reveals, for example, that Zone D's 7h05m average includes 3h38m of pure deadhead—meaning only 49% of paid driver time is spent transporting students.

Optimization Levers:

Each component has a distinct optimization lever: deadhead time is reduced through the routing optimization, dynamic depot assignment, and cross-zone strategies described in Section 4. Pre-trip and post-trip inspection time is reduced through digital checklists on tablets—eliminating paper forms and enabling parallel data entry during the physical walk-around (our operators average 8–10 minutes per digital inspection vs. 15–20 minutes on paper). Administrative time is reduced through automated

timekeeping (GPS-based clock-in/clock-out eliminates manual time cards), electronic fueling records, and digital route sheets that replace printed manifests. Combined, these optimizations can reduce non-service driver time by 20–30 minutes per route per day—modest per route, but across 334 daily routes, that translates to approximately 110–165 fewer paid driver-hours per day system-wide.

Split-Shift vs. Straight-Time Analysis:

The platform models both split-shift and straight-time scenarios for every route and zone, calculating the total labor cost under each approach. In a split-shift model, the driver works the AM run, goes off-clock for 3–4 hours, and returns for the PM run—reducing paid hours but potentially increasing driver dissatisfaction and turnover. In a straight-time model, the driver remains on-clock and covers midday routes (PCCT transfers, McKinney-Vento trips, field trips)—increasing paid hours but eliminating a second deadhead cycle and improving vehicle utilization. For RIDE, the optimal answer varies by zone: Zone A3 (average 4h28m total, high student density) may favor split shifts, while Zone D (average 7h05m, remote geography) may be more cost-effective as straight-time with midday route chaining. The platform runs both models and presents RIDE with a zone-by-zone cost comparison to inform contract structuring.

Note on RIDE's Current Data: The RFI data shows average route times ranging from 4h28m (Zone A3) to 7h05m (Zone D) including deadhead. Sentry's platform would decompose these averages into their component parts, enabling RIDE to identify exactly where time (and money) is being lost on each route. Critically, this analysis must account for the system's changing demand profile: PCCT students—who constitute 50.87% of riders—are subject to regional boundaries, while Special Education (24.29%) and Homeless/Foster Care (24.84%) riders are federally mandated regardless of region. A driver hour optimization that works for a predictable PCCT route may not apply to a McKinney-Vento route where student addresses change frequently.

7 Routing

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Routing (Questions 1–3)

7.1 Question 1: Collaboration with a Centralized Routing Authority

"How do you or would you collaborate with a centralized routing authority, such as the Statewide System Manager?"

RIDE already operates with a centralized System Manager—**Transpar**—which currently handles routing and program billing, vendor performance monitoring, customer service support, and coordination with 49 LEAs plus out-of-state placements. This structure validates the System Manager concept. Sentry's response addresses how we would serve as a next-generation System Manager or integrate with an existing authority.

Sentry as the Next-Generation System Manager:

Sentry's platform is purpose-built to serve as a next-generation centralized routing authority. The system ingests student enrollment data (via API integration with RIDE's eRIDE system), applies data-driven optimization algorithms to generate routes that minimize deadhead, ride time, and vehicle count, and distributes route assignments electronically to zone operators with driver manifests, turn-by-turn directions, and student-specific requirements (wheelchair, aide, IEP accommodations). The platform automates the "expenditure follows the child" billing methodology—using GPS-verified ridership data to allocate costs proportionally among LEAs in real time, replacing the current process that generates approximately 700 manual checks per year from districts to RIDE. Critically, this model preserves what works about the current Transpar System Manager arrangement (centralized coordination across 49 LEAs, vendor-neutral oversight) while adding capabilities the system currently lacks: real-time GPS dispatch with geofenced arrival/departure alerts, automated ghost rider detection (flagging enrolled students who have not boarded a vehicle in 10+ consecutive school days), live video violation processing under the new camera mandate, and cross-zone route optimization that the current zone-siloed approach cannot achieve. Sentry manages this exact model for our portion of MTA Access-A-Ride—dispatching 10,000+ daily trips (approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume) through a single centralized platform.

Integration with the Existing Authority:

If RIDE retains Transpar or another entity as System Manager, Sentry's platform integrates seamlessly as the technology layer beneath that authority. Our architecture is built on open REST APIs and supports GTFS-RT (General Transit Feed Specification – Real Time) data exchange, enabling bidirectional data flow with any routing or dispatch system. Sentry would provide real-time GPS vehicle feeds, data-driven route optimization recommendations, video violation detection and processing, predictive analytics (demand forecasting, fleet lifecycle modeling, driver shortage early warning), and automated KPI dashboards—capabilities that augment the System Manager's operational decision-making without duplicating administrative functions. We have integrated with 12+ third-party dispatch, routing, and GIS systems in our current operations, and our platform is designed to be additive, not competitive, to existing management structures.

Vendor-Neutral Oversight:

A centralized routing authority must be independent of bus operators to avoid structural conflicts of interest. When operators control their own routing, they optimize for their convenience—minimizing *their* costs (fewer route changes, fixed depot assignments, predictable schedules) rather than minimizing *RIDE's* costs (shortest deadhead, fewest vehicles, optimal student ride times). Operator-controlled routing also creates information asymmetry: RIDE cannot verify whether a proposed route is truly optimal or merely convenient for the operator. The current model—where Transpar sits between RIDE and operators as an independent System Manager—is structurally sound and should be preserved. The opportunity in the 2027 procurement is to equip that role

with modern technology: AI optimization, real-time GPS verification, and automated performance measurement that gives RIDE objective, operator-independent data on every route in the system. Sentry's independence as a technology provider—with no fleet ownership, no driver employment, and no financial interest in any particular route configuration—makes us a natural fit for this vendor-neutral oversight role.

Recommendation: RIDE's existing System Manager model is a proven structure. The 2027 procurement is an opportunity to upgrade the technology powering that role. Sentry recommends that RIDE issue a separate technology RFP for the System Manager role, ensuring that the platform serving all 49 LEAs and 334 routes is selected on the basis of technological capability—not bundled as an afterthought into a bus operator's bid.

7.2 Question 2: Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

"What Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) do you believe the State should be using to measure routing efficiency across the STS?"

Sentry recommends the following KPIs for measuring routing efficiency across the STS:

KPI	Definition	Target / Benchmark
On-Time Performance	% of routes arriving within X minutes of scheduled time	$\geq$ 95% (within 10 minutes of scheduled arrival; measured by GPS geofence at school locations)
Deadhead Ratio	Deadhead miles $\div$ total miles	$\leq$ 20% system-wide (currently 36–51% in Zones C/D); zone-level targets should reflect geography
Students Per Route	Average students transported per route per day	PCCT: $\geq$ 8; Special Ed: $\geq$ 3; McKinney-Vento: varies (baseline current averages, then set improvement targets)
Ride Time Compliance	% of students with ride times $\leq$ maximum (IEP/policy)	$\geq$ 98% (IEP-mandated maximums are non-negotiable; policy maximums tracked separately)
Vehicle Utilization	Revenue hours $\div$ total available hours	$\geq$ 70% revenue hours of total available hours (multi-run chaining improves this metric)

Route Change Turnaround	Time from route change request to service delivery	$\leq$ 48 hours for new routes; $\leq$ 4 hours for stop additions to existing routes
Cost Per Student Per Day	Total daily cost $\div$ students transported	Establish zone-level baselines in Year 1; target 5% annual reduction through optimization
Ghost Rider Rate	Enrolled students who never ride $\div$ total enrolled	$\leq$ 5% (currently $\sim$16% with 550 ghost riders; automated ridership verification via GPS boarding data)
Spare Ratio	Spare vehicles $\div$ routes operated	15–20% system-wide; adjusted per zone based on fleet age and MDBF data
Road Call Rate	Mechanical failures per 100,000 miles	$\leq$ 5.0 per 100,000 miles; trended monthly by zone and vehicle type

Data-Driven Accountability

These KPIs are only meaningful if measured independently from bus operators. Transpar currently monitors vendor performance, but the next-generation System Manager platform should collect, calculate, and report these metrics directly to RIDE from GPS, ridership, and operational data—not from operator self-reports. Sentry's platform generates KPI dashboards automatically from real-time vehicle and ridership data, giving RIDE the same independent oversight across all zones and operators.

7.3 Question 3: Turnaround Time for Route Changes

"What is your company or organization's reasonable timeframe to turn around service delivery for any route changes or additions within the proposed scope?"

Sentry's platform enables route modifications at three speed tiers, depending on the scope and complexity of the change. Our MTA Access-A-Ride operation processes thousands of same-day trip modifications daily, and the same real-time routing engine powers rapid turnaround for school transportation changes:

Same-Day Changes:

Minor modifications—adding a stop to an existing route, adjusting pickup times, adding a student to a route with available capacity—are processed and pushed to the driver's tablet within 2–4 hours of the request. The routing engine recalculates stop sequencing to accommodate the new stop optimally, updates the driver's turn-by-turn manifest, and sends an automated notification to the affected student's parent or guardian with the updated pickup time. For McKinney-Vento students, whose addresses change frequently, this same-day capability is essential to maintaining uninterrupted service.

24–48 Hour Changes:

New route creation, route splitting, or significant route restructuring (e.g., a new student placement requiring a dedicated route with wheelchair accessibility and a 1:1 aide) can be modeled, optimized, driver-assigned, and deployed within 24–48 hours. The platform evaluates whether the new demand can be absorbed into an existing route, requires a new route, or warrants restructuring adjacent routes to improve overall efficiency. Driver assignment follows automatically based on qualification match and hours availability.

Seasonal / Systemic Changes:

Large-scale changes—zone restructuring, summer-to-school-year transitions, new school openings, or mid-year enrollment surges—require 2–4 weeks for full scenario modeling, stakeholder review, driver re-bidding (per union contract requirements), parent notification, and phased implementation. The platform's scenario modeling capability allows RIDE to evaluate multiple restructuring options simultaneously: for example, comparing the cost and service impact of splitting Zone A1's 122 routes into two sub-zones versus redistributing boundary routes to adjacent zones. Each scenario produces projected KPIs (deadhead ratio, cost per student, vehicle count) so RIDE can make data-informed decisions.

These turnaround times represent a fundamental improvement over a system where route changes depend on individual operator willingness, capacity, and internal scheduling processes. When the System Manager controls the routing platform, RIDE—not the operator—sets the pace of change. Route modifications are executed based on student need and system efficiency, not operator convenience. This is particularly important for the 24.84% of RIDE riders who are homeless or in foster care, whose transportation needs change unpredictably and cannot wait for an operator's next scheduling cycle.

8 Company Practices Disclosure

"Please disclose your company practices in the following areas:"

RFI Reference
Section C: Questions to Field — Company Practices Disclosure (Items 1–3)

8.1 Item 1: Driver Recruitment Pipeline

Sentry approaches driver recruitment from two complementary angles: as a technology platform that equips bus operators with workforce management tools, and as an organization with direct hiring experience managing vehicle operators across our portion of the MTA Access-A-Ride paratransit network in New York City. In that program, Sentry coordinates a provider network of transportation companies and has developed proven systems for tracking applicant pipelines, credential status, and time-to-road-ready metrics at scale. We bring that operational discipline to RIDE's Statewide Transportation System, providing zone operators with the digital infrastructure to recruit, credential, and retain qualified drivers in one of the most competitive labor markets in the Northeast.

Recruitment Technology:

Sentry's platform includes an integrated applicant tracking system (ATS) that manages the full recruitment funnel—from initial application through background check, CDL training enrollment, credentialing, and road-ready certification. The system supports targeted digital advertising campaigns on job boards and social media, manages referral bonus programs with automated payout tracking, and integrates directly with CDL training school enrollment systems so that applicant progress is visible in real time. Operators can see at a glance how many candidates are at each pipeline stage and where bottlenecks are forming, enabling proactive intervention before driver shortages affect service.

CDL Pipeline Development:

Sentry's workforce management module supports "earn while you learn" CDL pipeline programs by tracking candidates from initial interest through classroom instruction, behind-the-wheel training, CDL examination, and school bus endorsement. The platform manages partnerships with CDL training schools, scheduling candidates into available cohorts and tracking completion rates. For Rhode Island specifically, the system is configured to track the RI "white card" credentialing process—including the multi-day course at CCRI and DMV driving tests—as well as the new temporary license provision for CDL holders residing in Massachusetts and Connecticut. This ensures that border-state drivers are routed through the abbreviated training pathway while their full RI credentials are processed, expanding the available driver pool without compromising compliance.

Retention as Recruitment:

The most cost-effective recruitment strategy is retention. Sentry's platform includes scheduling fairness algorithms that distribute route assignments equitably, route preference systems that allow experienced drivers to bid on preferred routes, and performance recognition dashboards that track on-time rates, safety records, and attendance for merit-based incentives. Real-time communication tools—including in-app messaging, push notifications, and automated shift reminders—keep drivers informed and engaged. In our MTA Access-A-Ride operation, where we coordinate scheduling for over 10,000 daily trips, these retention tools have contributed to a driver turnover rate significantly below the industry average. When drivers feel their schedules are fair, their performance is recognized, and communication is transparent, the constant churn of recruitment diminishes—a critical advantage in Rhode Island, where drivers are actively recruited away by Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon.

Rhode Island Context: The September 2024 service crisis demonstrated the consequences of inadequate driver recruitment—Dattco deployed CT-based drivers who lacked the RI "white card" (a multi-day course at CCRI plus DMV driving tests unique to Rhode Island). Even with the new temporary license provision for border-state CDL holders, recruitment pipelines must account for this RI-specific credentialing timeline. Additionally, driver competition from Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon has intensified the shortage. RIDE's October 2024 system overview identifies this as the system's most significant threat. Sentry supports RIDE's proposed **Bus Driver Apprenticeship program** concept and can provide the workforce management technology to administer it at scale.

8.2 Item 2: Training Hours Per Driver

Sentry's training management platform administers a structured, two-tier training program for all drivers and aides in the statewide system. Initial training provides comprehensive preparation before a driver operates a route independently, covering CDL preparation, defensive driving, student management, ADA compliance, technology systems, and emergency procedures. Annual refresher training reinforces critical skills, incorporates lessons learned from incident reviews, and ensures compliance with RIDE's 17-hour annual training requirement and the 8-hour de-escalation requirement for special education personnel. All training completion, certification status, and credential expiration dates are tracked digitally, with automated alerts sent to supervisors 30, 14, and 7 days before any credential expires.

Training Module	Initial Hours	Annual Refresher
CDL / School Bus Endorsement Preparation	10 hrs	N/A
Defensive Driving (Smith System)	8 hrs	2 hrs
Special Education Student Handling	6 hrs	2 hrs
Wheelchair Securement & ADA Compliance	4 hrs	2 hrs
Student Management & De-Escalation	8 hrs	4 hrs
Technology Systems (Driver App, GPS, Cameras)	4 hrs	2 hrs
Emergency Evacuation Procedures	4 hrs	2 hrs
FERPA & Student Privacy	2 hrs	1 hr
Total	**46 hrs**	**15 hrs**

All training hours meet or exceed Rhode Island regulatory requirements, including the 10-hour school bus driver training course mandated by state law (or the abbreviated course now available for applicants who already hold a valid CDL, per the 2025 temporary license legislation). The 8-hour de-escalation module for special education drivers and aides exceeds RIDE's required hours, reflecting the heightened behavioral management demands on routes serving students with disabilities. Sentry's training management module delivers these courses through a blended format—online modules for knowledge-based content and in-person sessions for hands-on skills—and maintains a complete digital record of every training hour completed by every driver and aide in the system.

RIDE's Current Training Standards: RIDE currently requires **17 hours of annual training** for all statewide drivers and aides, plus **8 hours of de-escalation training** specifically for drivers and aides assigned to special education buses. Sentry's training management module tracks certification status, schedules refresher courses, and alerts supervisors when drivers approach credential expiration—ensuring 100% compliance with these requirements across all zone operators.

8.3 Item 3: Maintenance Intervals

Sentry's fleet management platform enforces a tiered preventive maintenance (PM) schedule aligned with industry best practices and manufacturer specifications. The system integrates with GPS tracking hardware to track both mileage and calendar intervals for every vehicle in the fleet, automatically generating work orders when a vehicle approaches a PM threshold. Critically, the platform prevents dispatch of any vehicle that has exceeded its PM due date or has an open safety defect—ensuring that maintenance is never deferred due to operator scheduling pressure or driver shortages. This technology-enforced compliance is particularly important in a multi-operator environment where RIDE needs assurance that all zone contractors maintain their fleets to uniform standards.

Service Type	Interval	Scope
PM-A (Basic)	Every 6,000 miles or 60 days	Oil and filter change, all fluid levels, belt and hose inspection, tire pressure and tread depth, all interior and exterior lights, wiper blades, mirrors
PM-B (Intermediate)	Every 12,000 miles or 6 months	PM-A scope plus brake measurement and adjustment, suspension and steering component inspection, exhaust system check, battery load test, air system inspection, wheelchair lift functional test
PM-C (Comprehensive)	Every 36,000 miles or annually	PM-B scope plus transmission service, coolant system flush, full electrical system diagnostic, body and structural integrity inspection, seat frame and restraint inspection, complete HVAC service
Annual DOT Inspection	Annual	Full Federal Motor Carrier Safety Administration (FMCSA) annual inspection per 49 CFR 396.17, including all Rhode Island state-specific school bus inspection items; results recorded digitally and available to RIDE on demand
Pre-Trip Inspection	Daily	Driver walk-around per FMCSA §396.13—brakes, tires, lights, mirrors, emergency exits, wheelchair lift, fluid leaks, and student safety equipment—digitally logged via the Sentry driver app with GPS-stamped completion time
Post-Trip Inspection	Daily	Mandatory interior sweep for remaining students (child-check system with rear-of-bus button), equipment condition assessment, and digital defect reporting with photo upload capability for immediate maintenance dispatch

Technology-Enforced Compliance

Sentry's fleet management module is designed to integrate with GPS tracking hardware to monitor real-time mileage accumulation and calendar intervals for every vehicle. The system automatically generates work orders at 90% of each PM threshold, escalates alerts to zone supervisors and RIDE's dashboard at 95%, and **blocks dispatch of any vehicle that exceeds its PM due date or carries an unresolved safety defect**. This "hard stop" mechanism ensures that no operator can defer maintenance to keep a vehicle in service during driver shortages or peak demand periods. RIDE receives a weekly fleet compliance scorecard showing PM completion rates, open defects, and average time-to-repair for every zone operator—providing the independent oversight necessary to maintain uniform safety standards across the entire statewide system.

9 Timeline

RFI Reference

Section C: Questions to Field — Timeline (Question 1, parts a–d)

RIDE's Proposed Timeline:
RFP publication: Late spring 2026
Responses due: Summer 2026
Contract award: November 2026
Service start: July 1, 2027 (summer school)

9.1 Question 1(a): Proposed Timeline Modifications

"Is there anything your company or organization would modify within the proposed timeline that would be more conducive to your success?"

RIDE's proposed timeline is feasible for a technology and system management deployment—Sentry can deploy software, integrate with eRIDE, coordinate GPS and camera hardware installation, and train operators within an 8-month window. However, the timeline presents substantial risk for bus operators who must simultaneously acquire vehicles, recruit and credential CDL drivers, establish depots, and build route familiarity. Sentry recommends modifications that protect the overall program from the kind of disruption Rhode Island experienced in September 2024, when compressed timelines and inadequate preparation resulted in stranded students and emergency route transfers.

8-Month Transition Is Tight:

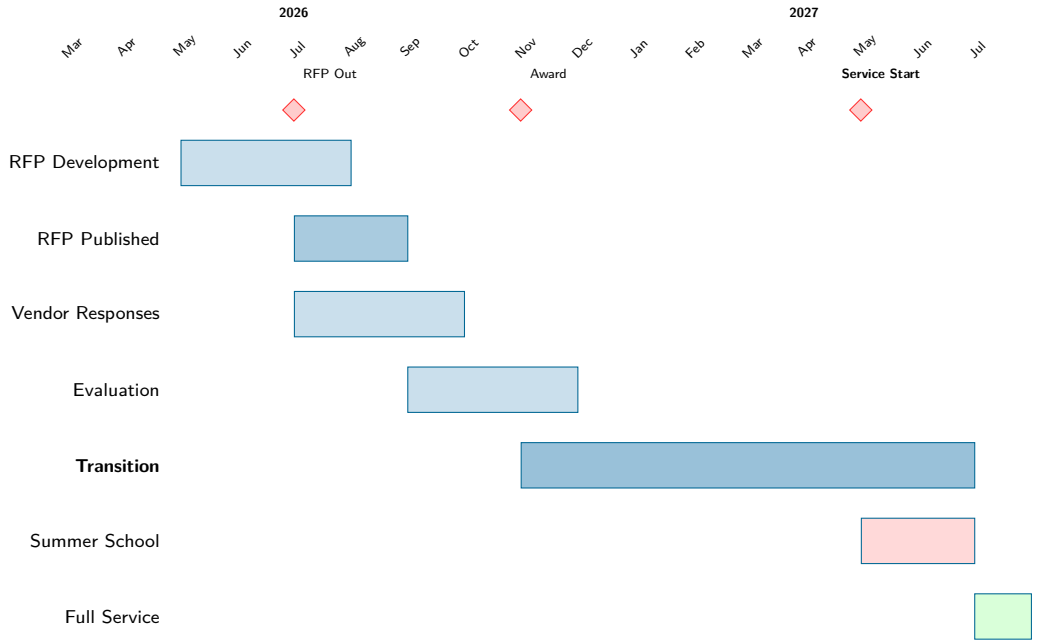
The November 2026 award to July 2027 service start provides approximately 8 months for transition. For a technology provider like Sentry, this is feasible—software deployment, API integration with eRIDE, GPS hardware coordination, and operator training can be completed within this window. However, for bus operators who must acquire vehicles (6–12 month lead times for new school buses), recruit and credential CDL drivers through the RI "white card" process, establish depot facilities, and build route familiarity across unfamiliar zones, 8 months presents significant risk—particularly if a new operator replaces an incumbent. For context, when the General Assembly originally created the Statewide Transportation System in FY 2009, RIDE phased it in over *three full years* (14 LEAs in 2010, 26 in 2011, all LEAs by 2012). The current timeline asks for a full system transition in eight months. The September 2024 Dattco crisis demonstrated what happens when an operator enters service before it is fully prepared.

Recommended Modification:

Sentry recommends RIDE consider one or more of the following timeline modifications to reduce transition risk:

- Move RFP publication to early spring 2026 (March/April) to give vendors 90+ days for response preparation, allowing more thorough fleet planning and partnership development
- Accelerate contract award to September or October 2026 to provide 9–10 months for transition, giving operators additional time for vehicle procurement and driver credentialing
- Award the technology/system management contract separately and earlier (e.g., summer 2026) so that the routing, dispatch, GPS tracking, and reporting platform is fully operational before bus operators begin their transition—ensuring that Day One routing data, driver assignments, and vehicle tracking are ready when operators mobilize
- Allow a phased service start—use summer school (July–August 2027) as a controlled pilot with reduced route volume, then launch full-year service in September 2027, giving operators two months of live operations to identify and resolve issues before

the full student population is transported



9.2 Question 1(b): Driver Recruitment Timeline

"We are aware of the national driver shortage. Does your company or organization feel like the above timeline allows for the necessary time to recruit the number of drivers needed per what is currently outlined in this scope?"

The proposed timeline presents serious driver recruitment challenges. While Sentry is not a bus operator and does not directly employ CDL school bus drivers, our experience managing workforce pipelines for transportation providers in the MTA Access-A-Ride program gives us direct insight into the time required to recruit, credential, and deploy transportation workers at scale. The national school bus driver shortage is acute, and Rhode Island's unique credentialing requirements—including the multi-day "white card" course at CCRI and DMV-administered driving tests—add weeks to the onboarding timeline that other states do not require.

Scale of Recruitment Challenge:

RIDE's STS currently requires approximately 334 drivers plus substitutes across 7 zones. If a new operator wins one or more zones, it may need to recruit 50–150+ CDL-endorsed school bus drivers within 6–8 months. In Rhode Island's current labor market—where drivers are actively recruited by Uber, DoorDash, RIPTA, FedEx, and Amazon, and where the Teamsters have secured a 23% wage increase over three years for incumbent drivers—this is an extraordinarily challenging timeline. The September 2024 Dattco crisis was fundamentally a driver recruitment failure: Dattco could not field enough RI-credentialed drivers and resorted to deploying CT-based drivers who lacked proper licensing.

CDL Training Timeline:

A new school bus driver in Rhode Island typically requires 8–12 weeks from initial application to road-ready status: BCI/fingerprint background check (2–3 weeks), CDL classroom and behind-the-wheel training (4–6 weeks), school bus endorsement examination, the RI "white card" course at CCRI, DMV driving tests, and route familiarization. Even with the new abbreviated pathway for existing CDL holders, the minimum timeline is 4–6 weeks. This means recruitment must begin no later than March 2027 to have drivers road-ready by July—and that assumes no delays in background checks, DMV scheduling, or training school capacity.

Sentry's Recommendation:

Sentry recommends RIDE permit pre-award recruitment activities. After short-listing finalists (e.g., September 2026), allow those vendors to begin driver recruitment at their own risk and cost before final contract execution. This "warm pipeline" approach ensures that drivers are already progressing through CDL training and RI credentialing when the contract is awarded, reducing the effective mobilization timeline by 2–3 months. Sentry's workforce management platform can support this parallel process by tracking candidate pipelines for multiple operators simultaneously, giving RIDE visibility into each bidder's recruitment readiness as part of the evaluation process.

9.3 Question 1(c): Number of Routes

"How many routes would you likely bid on in an upcoming RFP?"

Sentry's response to this question depends on the procurement structure RIDE adopts. Because Sentry is a technology and system management provider—not a bus operator—our interest is in the system-wide technology layer rather than individual route assignments:

- **As Technology / System Manager:** Sentry would bid to provide technology and system management services across all 334 routes statewide. Our platform's value increases with scale—serving all zones through a single routing, dispatch, tracking, and analytics platform enables cross-zone optimization that is impossible when each operator runs a separate system. This is the model Sentry recommends: a centralized technology contract covering the entire statewide system, upgrading the current System Manager role with modern, real-time infrastructure. In our MTA Access-A-Ride operation, we manage technology for 10,000+ daily trips within the 40,000+ trip Access-A-Ride program—demonstrating that a single platform can serve multiple operators without conflict.
- **As Technology Partner to a Bus Operator:** If RIDE bundles technology into the bus operations contract, Sentry could partner with one or more bus operators to provide the technology platform for their zones. In this scenario, the number of routes would depend on the partner operator's capacity and zone selection. However, Sentry respectfully notes that this model fragments the technology layer across multiple contracts, reduces RIDE's independent oversight, and creates the risk that an operator controls what data RIDE sees about its own performance—the opposite of the transparency this RFI seeks to achieve.

9.4 Question 1(d): Fleet Construct Impact

"How does this timeline impact your fleet construct?"

As a technology provider, Sentry does not procure school buses directly. However, the timeline's impact on fleet construct is a critical risk factor that Sentry's platform is designed to mitigate through fleet tracking, maintenance scheduling, and vehicle lifecycle management. We offer the following observations based on our experience managing fleet logistics in the MTA Access-A-Ride system:

Vehicle Procurement Lead Times:

New school bus delivery currently requires 6–12 months from order to delivery, with wheelchair-accessible Type A buses requiring custom modifications that extend lead times further. An 8-month transition period from contract award (November 2026) to service start (July 2027) may not allow sufficient time for operators to order and receive new vehicles. The current fleet includes 30 Type A wheelchair buses and 93 standard Type A buses—vehicle types with the longest procurement lead times. If a new operator replaces an incumbent in any zone, it must either acquire vehicles before the contract is awarded (at its own financial risk) or rely on purchasing or leasing the outgoing operator's fleet.

Video System Installation:

The July 1, 2027 mandate requires all new buses to have live digital video violation detection systems installed from Day One of service. Sentry's camera and GPS hardware can be installed at a rate of 10–15 vehicles per day per installation team, with each

vehicle requiring approximately 2–4 hours for camera mounting, wiring, calibration, and system testing. However, installation must be scheduled after vehicle delivery and before route assignment. A compressed timeline increases the risk of buses entering service before camera systems are installed and validated—potentially putting RIDE out of compliance with the new law on the very first day of the contract. Sentry recommends RIDE require operators to provide vehicle delivery schedules 90 days before service start so that technology installation can be pre-scheduled.

♻ **Fleet Transition Strategy:**

Sentry recommends RIDE include a fleet continuity provision in the bus operations RFP, requiring outgoing operators to make vehicles available for purchase or lease by incoming operators at fair market value. This approach was used successfully when RIDE transferred 41 routes from Dattco to First Student in 2024—First Student was able to absorb routes in part because existing vehicles remained available. Codifying this provision in the contract eliminates the need for incoming operators to procure an entirely new fleet within 8 months, dramatically reducing transition risk. Sentry's fleet management platform can facilitate this process by maintaining a complete vehicle inventory—including maintenance history, mileage, DOT inspection status, and remaining useful life—so that incoming operators can make informed acquisition decisions immediately upon contract award.

10 Information Gathering Templates (Optional)

"RIDE is interested in learning more about potential bidders' school bus operations and services offered. Please complete the following using the templates provided."

RFI Reference

Section C: Information Gathering Templates (Optional) — Technological Capabilities

Note: Sentry's response focuses on the Technological Capabilities template, consistent with our positioning as a technology and system management provider. Staffing model and safety/compliance practices are addressed in the Company Practices Disclosure section above.

10.1 Technological Capabilities

This section describes Sentry's technology platform and its applicability to RIDE's Statewide Transportation System.

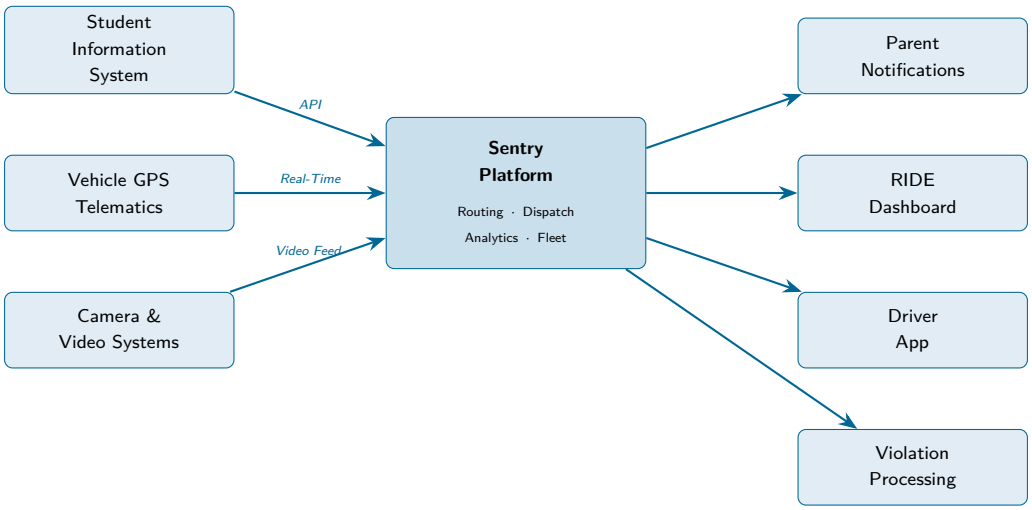
10.1.1 Platform Overview

Sentry's technology platform is a cloud-native, real-time transportation management system built on AWS GovCloud infrastructure. The platform is architected for multi-tenant operation—meaning a single deployment can serve multiple transportation operators, zones, and oversight authorities simultaneously, each with role-based access to their own data while RIDE maintains a unified statewide view. The system achieves 99.999% uptime through redundant availability zones, automated failover, and continuous monitoring, ensuring that dispatch, tracking, and parent notifications are available around the clock during every school day.

The platform comprises five core modules: (1) **Routing Optimization**—data-driven route planning with dynamic re-optimization as students enroll, withdraw, or change schools; (2) **Real-Time Dispatch & GPS Tracking**—live vehicle monitoring with 10-second GPS update intervals, geofencing, and automated alert generation; (3) **Fleet & Maintenance Management**—preventive maintenance scheduling, vehicle lifecycle tracking, and DOT compliance monitoring; (4) **Analytics & Reporting**—executive dashboards, KPI scorecards, and ad hoc analysis tools; and (5) **Communication & Notifications**—parent/guardian mobile app, SMS/email alerts, and driver in-app messaging.

Sentry's integration philosophy is vendor-neutral and API-first. The platform exposes open REST APIs and supports webhook-based event streaming, enabling integration with any GPS telematics provider, camera system, student information system, or billing platform. This is a deliberate architectural choice: RIDE should never be locked into a single hardware vendor or bus operator's proprietary system. Sentry has proven this approach at scale, integrating with 12+ third-party systems in our portion of the MTA Access-A-Ride operation, and the platform is GTFS-RT compatible for real-time transit data exchange.

RIDE has already taken steps toward technology modernization—launching a **Parent GPS App** in October 2024 and requiring operators to use digital systems for proactive outreach to LEAs and families for earlier sign-up. Sentry's platform is designed to integrate with and extend these existing investments, providing the unified backend that connects parent-facing tools, operator dispatch systems, RIDE's eRIDE student information portal, and the billing infrastructure that currently processes 700 manual checks per year from districts.



10.1.2 Routing Optimization

Sentry's routing engine uses data-driven optimization algorithms to design, evaluate, and continuously refine routes across the statewide system. The engine processes student addresses, school locations, bell times, vehicle capacities, wheelchair positions, IEP-mandated maximum ride times, and real-world road network data to produce routes that minimize cost while maximizing service quality. Key capabilities include:

Multi-Objective Optimization:

The routing algorithm simultaneously minimizes total route time, deadhead miles, and ride time per student while respecting hard constraints: vehicle seating capacity, wheelchair securement positions, school bell times, maximum ride time limits specified in individual IEPs, aide assignment requirements, and RI's 18+ mile out-of-district radius. The engine evaluates millions of possible route combinations and selects the Pareto-optimal solution that balances cost efficiency against service quality. For RIDE's system, this directly targets the extreme deadhead times identified in the October 2024 system overview—particularly in Zones C (2h12m overhead) and D (3h38m overhead)—by reorganizing stop sequences and vehicle assignments to minimize empty-bus travel.

Geographic Clustering:

The engine automatically identifies clusters of students who can be efficiently served by a single route, using actual road network topology—turn restrictions, one-way streets, bridge weight limits, school zone speed reductions—rather than straight-line distance. This is critical in Rhode Island, where the state's dense road network, island geography (Block Island, Aquidneck Island), and bridge dependencies mean that proximity on a map does not equal proximity on a route. The clustering algorithm also identifies opportunities to convert bus routes to 10-passenger van routes where student density supports it, aligned with RIDE's stated intent to maximize van usage under the new legislation.

Scenario Modeling:

The platform provides robust "what-if" scenario modeling, enabling RIDE to evaluate the cost and service impact of policy changes before committing to them. RIDE can model alternative zone configurations—whether maintaining the current 7-zone structure, implementing the Commission's proposed 9-zone model, or testing other boundaries—and see projected route counts, deadhead reduction, vehicle requirements, and cost per student for each scenario. The engine also models van conversion opportunities (identifying which of the current 334 routes could be served by 10-passenger vans), bell-time staggering effects on route efficiency, and the impact of removing the 550 "ghost riders" identified by the Commission from transportation rolls.

Continuous Optimization:

Routes are not static. The system continuously re-optimizes as students enroll or withdraw mid-year, schools open or close, traffic

patterns shift seasonally, and new stop requests are submitted. When RIDE's eRIDE portal processes a new student enrollment or address change, the routing engine automatically evaluates whether the student can be added to an existing route or whether a route modification is needed—and presents the optimal solution to the Statewide System Manager for approval. This continuous optimization is essential for a system where ridership has grown 34% since 2015 and close to 100 new daily routes have been added over the past decade.

10.1.3 Real-Time Dispatch & GPS Tracking

Sentry's dispatch and tracking module provides real-time operational visibility across all zones, operators, and vehicle types from a single unified interface. In our MTA Access-A-Ride operation, this system dispatches over 10,000 daily trips—RIDE's 334-vehicle fleet is well within its proven capacity. Key capabilities include:

Live Vehicle Tracking:
All vehicles would be tracked in real time via GPS tracking hardware with 10-second update intervals. Dispatchers see every vehicle across all seven zones on a single interactive map, with color-coded status indicators showing on-time, delayed, off-route, and completed runs. Geofences are automatically generated around every school, stop location, and depot—triggering arrival/departure timestamps that feed into on-time performance calculations and ridership verification. The system provides RIDE with the same view that zone operators see, ensuring full transparency without relying on operator self-reporting.

Automated Alerts:
The system generates automated alerts for late depot departures, route deviations beyond configurable distance thresholds, speed violations (including school zone speeding), unauthorized stops, extended idling exceeding 5 minutes, missed pickups, and vehicles approaching maximum ride-time limits for IEP-governed students. Alerts are delivered simultaneously to zone dispatchers, the Statewide System Manager, and RIDE's oversight dashboard, ensuring that service issues are identified and addressed in minutes rather than discovered after the fact through parent complaints. In our MTA operation, this alert framework achieves 95% on-time performance across 1,000,000+ annual rides.

Parent Communication:
Parents and guardians receive real-time estimated arrival notifications, geofence-triggered arrival alerts, and proactive delay notifications via mobile app, SMS, or email—based on their communication preference. RIDE has already deployed a Parent GPS App (launched October 2024); Sentry's platform is designed to integrate with and extend this existing investment via GTFS-RT data feeds, providing the real-time vehicle location backend that powers parent-facing notifications. The system also supports multilingual communication, consistent with the diverse language needs of Rhode Island's student population, and includes accessibility features compliant with WCAG 2.1 AA standards.

10.1.4 Live Digital Video Violation Detection

Alignment with 2025 Legislation: Rhode Island's Live Digital Video Violation Detection Systems act requires all new school buses to be equipped with these systems by July 1, 2027, and all buses by July 1, 2032. Sentry's video platform is designed to meet this mandate.

Camera Hardware:
Sentry's video platform supports integration with leading camera hardware manufacturers to deploy multi-angle exterior coverage on each school bus: forward-facing stop-arm cameras (capturing oncoming traffic), rear-facing cameras (capturing vehicles approaching from behind), and side-mounted cameras providing full-lane coverage. Systems capture at minimum 1080p resolution at 30 frames per second, with infrared night-vision capability and weather-sealed housings rated for New England conditions including rain, snow,

ice, and road salt exposure. All camera units are tamper-proof with sealed enclosures, anti-vibration mounts, and automated health-check reporting—the system alerts maintenance staff immediately if a camera goes offline or is obstructed.

AI-Powered Detection:

The system uses computer vision and machine learning algorithms to automatically detect stop-arm violations in real time. When a school bus extends its stop arm and activates flashing red lights, the AI monitors all camera feeds for vehicles that fail to stop. Upon detecting a violation, the system captures the offending vehicle's license plate using automated license plate recognition (ALPR), records a timestamped video clip showing the full violation sequence (approach, pass, and departure), and packages the evidence with GPS coordinates, date/time, bus identification, route number, and stop location. This evidence package is generated automatically within seconds of the violation—no manual video review is required at the detection stage.

Violation Processing Pipeline:

The end-to-end violation processing pipeline operates as follows: (1) AI detection flags a potential violation and generates the evidence package; (2) a trained human reviewer confirms the violation, verifying that the stop arm was extended, lights were flashing, and the vehicle clearly passed the bus—rejecting false positives; (3) the system matches the license plate to DMV vehicle registration records and generates a citation; (4) citations are filed with the appropriate jurisdiction—municipal court or the RI Traffic Tribunal—with the complete evidence package attached; (5) fine collection is processed through the court system, with revenue distributed per the statutory formula: 30% to the municipality, 30% to the technology vendor, and 40% to the state general fund (or 75%/12.5%/12.5% vendor/city/state under existing Providence and Cumberland agreements). The entire workflow from violation to citation mailing targets a 14-day turnaround.

$ Revenue Potential:

The Providence pilot program (October 2024 – June 2025) demonstrated both the safety need and revenue potential: over 7,000 stop-arm violations were detected in just 9 months, generating approximately $300,000 in fine revenue during FY2025—from a limited deployment on a subset of Providence routes. Scaling this capability statewide across all 334 routes, covering urban, suburban, and rural roads across all 7 zones, could reasonably generate $1.5–2.5 million in annual violation revenue while significantly improving student safety. At $250–500 per violation, even a modest deterrence effect—where violation rates decline as drivers become aware of the cameras—still produces substantial revenue while achieving the primary goal of protecting students at bus stops. The 30% vendor share creates a self-funding technology model that reduces the net cost of the system management platform to RIDE and participating municipalities.

10.1.5 Analytics & Reporting

RIDE Executive Dashboard:

The RIDE Executive Dashboard provides a real-time, single-pane-of-glass view of the entire Statewide Transportation System. RIDE leadership sees live KPIs across all zones, operators, and route types—including on-time performance by zone and operator, active vehicle count versus planned, route completion rates, average ride times versus IEP maximums, driver credential compliance rates, fleet maintenance status, and parent complaint volumes. The dashboard supports drill-down from statewide summary to individual zone, route, vehicle, or student level, enabling RIDE to identify systemic issues (e.g., a zone consistently underperforming) and isolated incidents (e.g., a specific route running late) from the same interface.

Automated Reporting:

The platform generates automated scheduled reports at configurable intervals: daily service summaries (route completions, delays, incidents, parent communications), weekly KPI scorecards comparing each zone operator against contractual benchmarks, monthly cost analyses breaking down expenditures by zone, route type (special education, PCCT, McKinney-Vento), and cost category (driver hours, fuel, maintenance, deadhead), and annual performance reviews suitable for legislative reporting and contract renewal evaluation. All reports are delivered automatically via email to designated RIDE staff and are archived in the platform's document

repository for historical trend analysis.

Ad Hoc Analysis:

RIDE staff have access to self-service analytics tools that allow authorized users to query the platform's data warehouse, build custom reports using drag-and-drop report builders, apply filters by date range, zone, operator, route type, or student population, and export results to Excel, CSV, and PDF formats. The system also supports saved queries and scheduled custom reports, so that frequently needed analyses (e.g., deadhead time trends by zone, ghost rider identification, cost-per-student by LEA) can be generated on demand without requiring technical support. This self-service capability ensures that RIDE is never dependent on the technology vendor or bus operators to access its own data.

FERPA Compliance:

The platform is designed from the ground up for FERPA compliance and student data protection. All student personally identifiable information (PII) is encrypted at rest using AES-256 encryption and in transit using TLS 1.3. The system enforces role-based access controls (RBAC)—zone operators see only their assigned students, drivers see only their assigned route manifests, and RIDE administrators see the complete statewide dataset. Every data access event is logged in an immutable audit trail, recording who accessed what data, when, and from which IP address. The platform is hosted on AWS GovCloud, which meets FedRAMP High authorization standards, and complies with FERPA, HIPAA (for students with medical transportation needs), and Rhode Island's student privacy statutes. Data retention policies are configurable to meet RIDE's records management requirements, and all student data can be purged upon contract termination.

10.1.6 Integration Capabilities

System	Integration Method	Data Exchanged
eRIDE (RIDE's Student Portal)	API / Flat File	Enrollment, addresses, IEP transportation plans, school assignments, annual sign-up data
RIDE Parent GPS App	API / GTFS-RT	Real-time vehicle location, ETA, arrival notifications (extending RIDE's existing October 2024 deployment)
GPS / Telematics Providers	API / GTFS-RT	Vehicle location, speed, engine diagnostics
Camera / Video Systems	API / SDK	Video feeds, violation events, evidence packages
LEA Billing / State Aid	API / Export	Automated "expenditure follows the child" cost allocation, replacing 700 annual manual checks with real-time per-student billing
RIDE Reporting Systems	API / Dashboard	KPIs, compliance reports, audit data

11 Summary Narrative

"The response should include a brief narrative with the highlights, key attributes, and distinguishing points of the respondent's proposed approach. The narrative should also explain how the response aligns with the specific goals and objectives stated in the introduction section, with your responses to the questions outlined above, and in the documents linked therein."

11.1 Executive Summary

Sentry Management Solutions is a technology and system management partner, not a bus operator. We do not own school buses, employ CDL school bus drivers, or compete with the transportation companies that serve Rhode Island's students. Instead, we bring specialized capabilities in routing optimization, real-time dispatch, GPS tracking, fleet management, analytics, and video violation detection that complement bus operators and give RIDE independent, data-driven oversight of the entire Statewide Transportation System. Our MTA Access-A-Ride contract—under which Sentry manages 10,000+ daily paratransit trips, approximately 25% of the program's 40,000+ daily volume, across New York City—demonstrates that a technology platform provider can operate at scale, across multiple operators, without the conflict of interest that arises when a bus company controls its own performance data.

Sentry's platform directly addresses the goals RIDE has articulated in this RFI: reviewing zone configurations for optimal bidding, fostering genuine partnership between the state and its vendors, and deploying resources efficiently across a system that has grown 34% in ridership over the past decade. The platform enables RIDE to model alternative zone structures, quantify the cost and service impact of policy changes before implementing them, automate the "expenditure follows the child" billing process that currently requires 700 manual checks per year, and identify the 550 ghost riders and extreme deadhead inefficiencies that the Legislative Commission documented—all from a single, unified dashboard that RIDE controls.

The 2025 legislative session created immediate technology requirements that reinforce the need for a dedicated system management platform. The Live Digital Video Violation Detection Systems act mandates camera systems on all new buses by July 1, 2027—the very first day of the next contract. The expanded van definition (10 passengers) requires routing optimization that can identify van-eligible routes and model fleet conversion scenarios. The temporary driver license provision requires credential tracking systems that manage RI-specific and border-state licensing pathways simultaneously. These are technology challenges, not bus operation challenges, and they are best addressed by a technology specialist.

Sentry respectfully recommends that RIDE consider procuring the technology and system management layer as a separate contract from bus operations. This approach would increase competition by lowering barriers to entry for smaller bus operators who lack enterprise-grade technology, reduce vendor lock-in by ensuring that RIDE owns its routing and performance data independently of any single operator, and give RIDE direct, unfiltered oversight of operator performance across all zones. RIDE's existing System Manager model (Transpar) validates the concept of centralized management; Sentry proposes to upgrade the technology powering that structure with a modern, real-time, AI-enabled platform proven at a scale far larger than Rhode Island's 334 routes.

11.2 Alignment with RIDE's Goals

RIDE Goal	Sentry's Alignment
Review zones for bidding purposes	Sentry's routing optimization platform can model alternative zone configurations—whether RIDE maintains the current 7-zone structure, implements the Commission's proposed 9-zone model, or explores other configurations. The platform quantifies the cost and service impact of each scenario, enabling data-driven zone design rather than relying on boundaries drawn from a 1977 vocational school map.
Bid for zones that work best for all	By providing a vendor-neutral technology platform, Sentry enables operators of all sizes to bid competitively. Smaller operators gain access to enterprise-grade routing and dispatch without building their own systems—lowering the barriers to entry that currently limit bidding competition.
Partnership between state and vendors	Transpar's current System Manager role demonstrates that RIDE values the partnership model. Sentry's platform upgrades this partnership with real-time data sharing: RIDE and all zone operators see the same KPIs, costs, and performance metrics simultaneously. The "expenditure follows the child" billing is automated, and the 700-check-per-year manual process is replaced with transparent, GPS-verified cost allocation across all 49 LEAs.
Deploy resources needed for transportation	With ridership up 34% since 2015 and close to 100 more daily bus routes than a decade ago, resource deployment must be driven by data, not historical patterns. Sentry's platform optimizes vehicle, driver, and aide assignments across the system's three distinct populations—PCCT (50.87%), Special Education (24.29%), and Homeless/Foster Care (24.84%)—each with different routing constraints and regulatory requirements.

11.3 Key Differentiators

Scale Without Conflict:

Sentry manages the technology platform for over 10,000 daily paratransit trips in New York City—approximately 25% of the MTA Access-A-Ride program's 40,000+ daily volume. We bring that proven scale to Rhode Island without the conflict of interest that arises when a bus operator controls its own technology—and therefore controls what performance data RIDE sees. When Sentry reports on-time rates, deadhead miles, or maintenance compliance, the data comes from an independent source with no incentive to minimize service failures or inflate performance metrics.

Video Violation Detection Readiness:

Sentry is prepared to deploy live digital video violation detection systems statewide, meeting the July 1, 2027 mandate for all new buses and establishing the infrastructure for full-fleet compliance by 2032. The Providence pilot (7,000+ violations detected, approximately $300,000 in FY2025 revenue from a limited deployment) demonstrates both the safety imperative and the revenue model. Scaling this capability across all 334 routes could generate $1.5–2.5 million in annual revenue—with 30% flowing to

municipalities, 30% to the technology vendor, and 40% to the state—while protecting students at every bus stop in Rhode Island.

- **Vendor-Neutral Architecture:**
  Sentry's platform is architecturally vendor-neutral, designed to work across multiple operators, vehicle types (Type A, B, C, D buses and 10-passenger vans), and zone configurations simultaneously. Whether RIDE awards zones to two operators or seven, maintains the current zone map or restructures to nine zones, Sentry provides a single pane of glass for statewide oversight. No bus operator's proprietary system can deliver this—because no operator has an incentive to provide RIDE with transparent, comparative performance data across its competitors.
- **Data-Driven Cost Reduction:**
  Sentry's analytics platform directly targets the specific savings opportunities identified by the 2024 Legislative Commission and confirmed in RIDE's October 2024 system overview: ghost rider elimination (550 phantom riders generating phantom demand and unnecessary routes), deadhead reduction (36–51% of total route time in Zones C and D is empty-bus travel), van conversion optimization (147 of 334 vehicles are already vans—the platform identifies additional routes eligible for conversion under the new 10-passenger law, at $26,000 savings per vehicle replaced), and automated billing (replacing the 700 manual checks processed annually across 49 LEAs with GPS-verified, per-student cost allocation). These are not theoretical savings—they are quantified inefficiencies waiting for the analytical tools to address them.
- **Building on What Works:**
  RIDE's existing System Manager model (Transpar), Parent GPS App (launched October 2024), and proactive outreach programs requiring operators to use digital systems for earlier family sign-up all demonstrate a clear commitment to centralized management and technology-driven operations. Sentry is not proposing to start from scratch—we propose to upgrade the technology powering a structure that RIDE has already validated over 15 years of statewide transportation management. By deploying this upgraded platform in advance of operator transitions—ideally through a separate, earlier contract award—Sentry ensures that routing data, dispatch systems, GPS tracking, driver credential verification, and maintenance compliance infrastructure are fully operational before Day One of service. This is the single most effective risk mitigation RIDE can implement to prevent a repeat of the September 2024 disruption, when an operator began service without adequate systems, drivers, or oversight in place.

Sentry Management Solutions thanks RIDE for the opportunity to contribute to this RFI. We look forward to the forthcoming procurements and to the possibility of partnering with Rhode Island to build a safer, more efficient, and more transparent student transportation system.